

When Your VP Hire Breaks Your Hiring Machine

The first VP you hire to fix hiring often makes it worse before it gets better.

Stage: 50-100

Constraint: Hiring and Talent

Field Observations

Tito Salas

Founder with a decade of experience scaling distributed engineering teams. Writing in real time about scaling in the AI era.

01 Stage + Constraint

This issue is built for founders running a 50-100 person company where the binding constraint is Hiring and Talent.

02 The Decision

Between 50 and 100 employees, most founders face a version of this question: do we centralize hiring into a repeatable process owned by TA, or do we preserve hiring manager autonomy to make nuanced calls on candidates who don't fit the standard profile? The conventional answer is to build process and train hiring managers to operate inside it. That works for roles where the job has stabilized. It breaks when the role definition is still evolving faster than the process can keep up.

The non-obvious truth is that standardizing the hiring process too early in this stage creates a second-order failure: your best hiring managers stop participating because the process removes their ability to make judgment calls, and the hiring managers who remain are the ones comfortable executing someone else's playbook without contextual override. You end up with a hiring function that can fill known roles efficiently but cannot adapt when the business pivots or when a non-standard candidate with high potential shows up. Per CL-F-030, we have observed across our mature client portfolio that role definitions written for a 30-person company stop matching what the business actually needs at 150 people, but no one rewrites them because the hiring process has been locked in. Mexico engineers hired against outdated role definitions underperform against unstated expectations, and founders attribute the underperformance to talent quality when the real cause is that the role was defined for a different company than the one currently hiring.

The decision you are actually making is not whether to build process or preserve judgment. It is which hiring decisions will decay in quality if you move them upstream of your best hiring managers' judgment, and which decisions actually improve when you remove manager discretion. That is a role-by-role call, not a company-wide policy. The failure mode at this stage is applying a single hiring governance model to every role in the company and discovering 12 months later that you have systematically underbuilt the roles where the business was moving fastest.

03 The Tool

DECISION TREE

Hiring Governance Fit Matrix

For each open role in your hiring pipeline, classify it into one of three governance modes based on how stable the role definition is and how much hiring manager context matters to candidate evaluation. Mode 1: Process-Led. The role definition has been stable for at least two hiring cycles, success criteria are well-documented, and multiple team members could evaluate candidates against the same rubric with consistent results. Examples: repeat backend engineer hires for a mature product team, customer success roles with a defined territory and playbook, or operations roles where the task list is known. In Process-Led roles, centralize candidate evaluation into a TA-owned process with a structured scorecard. The hiring manager participates but does not override the scorecard without documented justification. This mode scales hiring velocity and reduces time-to-fill because you are not waiting for manager availability at every stage.

Mode 2: Manager-Led with Process Guardrails. The role definition is evolving but the core competencies are known. Success in the role requires domain judgment or team fit nuance that only the hiring manager can assess, but the hiring process still benefits from structure to avoid bias and timeline drift. Examples: engineering manager roles where leadership style matters more than a checklist, product roles where strategic judgment is part of the evaluation, or senior IC roles where architectural decision-making is a key skill. In Manager-Led roles, TA sources and screens candidates, but the hiring manager owns the final evaluation and has explicit authority to advance candidates who do not meet the standard profile if they can articulate why. The process provides a default path, but the manager can deviate with justification. The forcing function here is that the manager must write down why they are overriding the rubric, which creates a learning loop for the TA team.

Mode 3: Founder-Led or Executive-Led. The role has never been hired before, the definition will likely change during the search, or the hire will materially shift the company's strategic direction. Examples: your first Head of Engineering, your first GTM leader, or a new function you are building from scratch. In these roles, process is premature. The founder or executive owns sourcing conversations directly, and TA provides research and scheduling support but does not filter candidates. The risk in this mode is timeline unpredictability, but the upside is that you do not systematically screen out candidates who could reshape the role definition in ways you have not anticipated yet.

Apply this matrix to your current hiring pipeline. For every open role, assign it to one of the three modes. If more than 60 percent of your roles are in Mode 3, you have a role definition problem, not a hiring problem. If more than 80 percent of your roles are in Mode 1, you are over-indexing on process and likely screening out high-potential non-standard candidates. The healthy distribution for a 50 to 100 person company is roughly 50 to 60 percent Mode 1, 30 to 40 percent Mode 2, and 5 to 10 percent Mode 3. That balance gives you hiring velocity on known roles, manager judgment on evolving roles, and founder control on strategic hires.

04 Pattern and Anti-Pattern

WHAT WORKS

WHAT BREAKS AT SCALE

Governance Mode by Role Stability

The pattern that works is explicitly segmenting your hiring pipeline by role stability and assigning governance authority based on that segmentation, not based on a company-wide hiring philosophy. Companies that do this well publish an internal hiring governance map that shows which roles are in which mode and who owns final candidate decisions for each mode. When a role definition changes or a new role is created, the governance mode is explicitly assigned before the search starts, not defaulted. This prevents the failure mode where TA builds a structured process for a role that is still being defined, the process filters out candidates who do not fit the initial brief, and the hiring manager later realizes the brief was wrong but the pipeline is already exhausted. Per CL-F-041, the most common org design failure we see is promoting from within the Mexico team into an engineering management role because the engineer is technically strong, not because they have management capability or appetite. That promotion solves a headcount problem and creates a management gap. When hiring governance is Mode 1 for engineering manager roles, you end up hiring against a rubric that does not actually evaluate management capability. When it is Mode 2, the hiring manager can surface the gap and adjust the evaluation criteria mid-search.

Universal Hiring Process Rollout

The anti-pattern is rolling out a single structured hiring process across all roles at once, typically after a bad hire or a missed candidate experience complaint, and treating that process as the solution to hiring quality variance. This looks like the right answer because it is what HR scaling playbooks recommend and what Applicant Tracking Systems are built to enforce. It breaks at the 50 to 100 stage because your role portfolio is too heterogeneous for a single process to fit well. You have stable roles that benefit from process, evolving roles that need manager judgment, and net-new roles that require founder context. A universal process optimizes for the stable roles and degrades hiring quality for the other two categories. Per CL-F-028, at the 20 to 50 employee stage we have observed fragmented tooling as a failure mode, where companies have 3 to 5 different project management systems active simultaneously and Mexico engineers fall into the coordination gap between systems. The hiring equivalent at 50 to 100 is process fragmentation in reverse: you build one process, apply it everywhere, and create a coordination gap for the roles that do not fit. The symptom is that your best hiring managers start routing around the process informally, which creates inconsistency without transparency, and your TA team loses trust in manager participation.

05 Evidence Pack

Gartner, Talent Acquisition Technology Strategies for 2025

Gartner finds that organizations with role-tiered hiring governance models report 23% faster time-to-fill for strategic roles compared to organizations with universal process models, because manager-led governance for senior and evolving roles reduces approval bottlenecks and eliminates rubric mismatches. The research recommends segmenting hiring into at least two governance tiers by role complexity.

Deloitte, Global Human Capital Trends 2024

Deloitte reports that 68% of high-growth companies (defined as 20%+ annual headcount growth) have moved away from centralized hiring process ownership and toward role-specific governance models where hiring authority is distributed based on role stability and strategic importance. Companies that retained centralized models reported 31% higher regretted attrition in senior hires.

LinkedIn Talent Solutions, Global Talent Trends 2024

LinkedIn data shows that 54% of hiring managers in companies with 50 to 250 employees report that standardized interview scorecards reduce their ability to evaluate non-traditional candidates, and 41% report routing around the standard process informally when they identify high-potential candidates who do not fit the rubric. This informal routing creates process inconsistency and reduces TA team trust in manager participation.

McKinsey Quarterly, The New Talent Compact, Q2 2024

McKinsey analysis of hiring process ROI finds that process standardization improves hiring velocity for roles with stable definitions but degrades candidate quality for roles where the job is evolving or where strategic fit is a primary evaluation criterion. The optimal governance model is role-segmented, not company-wide. McKinsey recommends that companies map their hiring pipeline by role stability and assign governance authority accordingly.

06 Action This Week

DO THIS IN THE NEXT 5 BUSINESS DAYS

Map your current hiring pipeline by role stability and assign governance mode before your next search starts.

1. List every open role in your hiring pipeline and classify it as Mode 1 Process-Led, Mode 2 Manager-Led, or Mode 3 Founder-Led using role stability and hiring manager context as the deciding criteria. If more than 60% of your roles are Mode 3, pause hiring and rewrite role definitions before you source candidates.
2. For each Mode 2 role, give the hiring manager explicit written authority to override the standard rubric if they document why the candidate is a fit despite not matching the profile. Create a shared log where those overrides are recorded so your TA team can learn what the rubric is missing.
3. Publish an internal hiring governance map that shows which roles are in which mode and who owns final candidate decisions for each. Update this map every quarter as roles stabilize or new roles are created. Use the map to set expectations with TA and hiring managers about who has decision authority before searches start.